Gwen and Gwen

By Nancy Kiefer

Suggested Roles -- Actress 1: Gwen Actress 2: Gwen II and Mother

NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Gwen stands in the center of the room, very nervous and waiting expectantly for something; phone rings; she takes the receiver off the hook, but it continues to ring. She grabs a broom to frantically sweep the floor. A pounding at the door; she looks at her watch)

GWEN: **(Pg 15-17)** Seven o'clock . . . seven o'clock . . . Estelle'll call at nine . . . at nine. *(Faces the door directly)* I got nothing to say to you! I got my own apartment now! You'd just make fun of it, but it's mine! And a job! A job you'd laugh at, but I got a job! *(Pounding continues; phone begins to ring again)* And I got a friend! Estelle is my friend, and you can say anything you want, but she's my friend! And I'm gonna get my kids back, too! You can pound on the door and let the phone ring all night, but I won't talk to you! I won't!

(pounding on the door and the phone ringing stop; the door suddenly bursts open. Gwen II is standing in the doorway, annoyed. She enters the apartment and slams the door behind her)

GWEN II: What's with you, Gweny? Don't you believe in answering your phone anymore? Your neighbors aren't going to appreciate it if you let your goddam phone ring all the time. They'll report you and you'll get your ass thrown out. Besides . . . what if it was ***him***? What if ***he*** was trying to call you?

GWEN: *(Weakly)* . . . please . . . please go away.

GWEN II: Like hell! I need a home just as much as you do! You know what you are, Gwen? You are ***inconsiderate***. You found a home for your kids. You found a padded cell for yourself to hide in. What about me, huh?

GWEN: I was not in a padded cell. I was in a group home.

GWEN II: *(critically surveys the room)* What a crummy dump this is. You're in big trouble, Gweny.

(Looks at Gwen for a long time)

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INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *The voice . . . HER voice was back. Stronger than ever. And now Gwen not only could hear her . . . she could see her too.*
ACTRESS 2: *Life is often hard, but it's even harder when you are battling a mental illness.*
TOGETHER: *Gwen and Gwen by Nancy Kiefer*

GWEN II: **(Pg 17-18)** You're looking well, Gwen. Certainly better than when we parted company a year ago. So how's the kids? They been split up and put into foster homes yet?

GWEN: Get out of here! This is ***my*** apartment.

GWEN II: Tell me about this Estelle woman.

GWEN: She was my social worker at the home. And she's . . . she's my friend.

GWEN II: If they took her paycheck away, would she still come around? Would she still be your friend? Let's get her fired and find out.

GWEN: She's going to call me at nine.

GWEN II: So what? Is that supposed to intimidate me? Am I supposed to be scared or something *(Laughs)* **(Pg 20-21)** So what happened to that broad who was supposed to move in here with you? How come she didn't, huh?

GWEN: Billie . . . her name was Billie. She was . . . sad. She couldn't take care of her children. Billie had to go back to the hospital. She had a relapse. But before that we shared a room in the group home. We talked a lot . . . watched television at night.

GWEN II: *(cuts her off)* Sounds like a real drag. Two losers who deserted their kids sittin' around watchin' the idiot tube and poppin' antidepressants.

GWEN: You haven't changed a bit, have you?

GWEN II: *(Intensely)* Did you really think you could put me in permanent cold storage, Gwen? That a few months in a padded cell with some soggy social worker tellin' you that you're really ***not*** a *screw*-up would get rid of me? *(menacing whisper)* All I did was wait . . . I just waited. *(Gwen laughs nervously)* **(Pg 22)** *(threateningly)* And don't laugh at me, or I'll slap that smile off your ugly face. Don't laugh at me and don't abandon me again. **(Pg 25)** *(Hits Gwen across the face)* Don't you ever again pay some jailor to suppress me into nothingness so you can pretend for a few months that you're sane! *(She calms herself)*

GWEN: **(Pg 23)** You are so jealous . . . so jealous!

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GWEN II: **(Pg 26)** Yes, Gwen. I'm jealous . . . of everyone whose parents are kind and wise and who grew up smart and pretty and loved. I'm jealous of every woman he touched, every woman he wanted. **(Pg 30)** You are the guilt and I am the jealousy. You were always the one who felt certain that every time somebody got shit on, it was your fault. You were the one who took the blame and I was the one who hated. You were the martyr and I was avenger. What a pair, what a team.

GWEN: Get out! Just get out of here!

******** one week later********

GWEN II: **(Pg 36-37)** *(tenses up and looks around the room, sniffing)* I smell a rat! Someone's coming.

GWEN: *(Panicky)* My mother?! My mother?! I don't want to see her! I don't want to talk to her! What should I do? *(firm knock on the door)* Go away! Go into the bathroom! Don't talk to me! *(GWEN II complies and exits) (Gwen answers the door)* Mom . . . Mom . . . you didn't call . . . I wasn't expecting you.

MOTHER: *(looks critically around the room)* Good lord! **(Pg 38-39)** I know the rent's cheap, but really Gwen. There must be rats and roaches here. No matter where we lived, Gwen, I always kept it clean. You've been here for over a week. Don't tell me you haven't had time to clean.

GWEN: Mom . . . it's been hard for me. Hard to go back to work. I guess when I come home, I feel . . . I feel . . . depressed.

MOTHER: *(Starting to clean)* Everybody gets depressed, Gwen. Do you think you're the only person? Besides, I thought that year you spent in that . . . home was supposed to make you well again. Your sister took your children in for an entire year!

GWEN: **(Pg 40-41)** I know I've been a big inconvenience to everyone, Mom. **(Pg 41)** I never expected Kathleen to take care of the kids forever.

MOTHER: Well, I should hope not. You had them, Gwen. You married a man I begged you not to marry and had children with him. I warned you he'd never support you. You wouldn't listen, and now those children are your responsibility. Not your sister's and certainly not mine.

GWEN: I can change . . .

MOTHER: . . . I hope so, Gwen. Men have affairs and leave their wives all the time. Life has to go on. I have never been able to understand why you allowed yourself to fall to pieces like you did.

GWEN: Mom . . . Mom . . I guess . . it was more than that. *(starts to cry)*

MOTHER: **(Pg 42-43)** *(stops cleaning and looks critically and unsympathetically at GWEN)* Snap out of it, Gwen. I did not come here to listen to you whine.

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GWEN: I'm sorry. I've just . . .just got a lot of problems, Mom.

MOTHER: Well don't blame them on me. You can't go through life blaming other people for your problems, Gwen. At some point you have to take responsibility and shape up – or ship out.

GWEN: You're right . . . you're right *(trying to stop crying)* I'm grateful for everything you've done for me.

MOTHER: You've had your year of relaxation! Now it's time to get back to work.

GWEN: *(Astonished)* I wasn't relaxing, Mom. *(Confused)* Mom . . . Exactly what do you want me to do?

MOTHER: **(Pg 44)** I want you to stop thinking about yourself, Gwen. Think of your children. They are far more important than you . . . You were always look[ing] for attention. I think you've had enough for one year, don't you? Your sister's divorced and she's been jilted by men, but she didn't abandon ***her*** children. *(a long beat)*

GWEN: **(Pg 45)** *(obviously fighting to remain civil)* Mom . . . you getter go home. Dad might need you. I can finish this.

MOTHER: *(Relieved Mother grabs her coats and prepares to leave)* But will you? *(Smiles coldly at her)* I didn't raise my children to live in pig pens. *(Exits)*

GWEN II: *(explodes out of the bathroom)* Get outta here, you bitch!!! *(to Gwen)* Just because there's some obscure code of human ethics that says you're supposed to feel gratitude towards your parents, you don't have to go along with it! Name one thing she ever did for you! I hate her! Parenting skills of a f***** rattlesnake. People like her shouldn't be allowed to breed.

GWEN: **(Pg 47)** I'm not like you . . . I can't talk like you. **(Pg 48-49)** *(repeating a litany she's clearly said over and over)* My mother is kind. She is thoughtful and caring. I'm not going to let you destroy the progress I made.

GWEN II: Progress? Look around you, Gweny. Look at this mess. Does this look like the home of a woman who's made progress?

GWEN: *(looks around her and then closes her eyes)* . . . yes. Because all it means is that I'm out of the group home and on my own.. It doesn't matter what the place looks like.

GWEN II: Where are your kids? You haven't got the guts to call them! You still can't stand up to your mother. You call that progress? **(Pg 50)** I get [so] tired of you, Gwen. I get tired of what a spineless, uninteresting loser you are! *(to herself)* Damn her. Damn her to hell!

GWEN: **(Pg 51)** *(softly to herself, overlapping Gwen II's last line)* . . . and I'm going to get them back just as soon as I can . . .just as soon as I can . . . just as soon . . . **(Pg 56)** I want to see them . . . I do . . . [but] I don't want them to see me like this.

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******* one month later *******

GWEN II: **(Pg 59)** You're stupid and you're also a pathological liar!

GWEN: **(Pg 60)** Why do you talk like that?

GWEN II: I beg your pardon. I don't talk like that. You talk like that. If somebody walked in here right now, who would they see? Just you, sittin' around talkin' to yourself. You're becoming dysfunctional.

GWEN: *(Angrily)* Alright! Alright! And why am I dysfunctional? Does it have anything to do with your existence?

GWEN II: I come in when you let me in. I come in when you hate yourself and when your guilt is eating you up like a cancer. I'm all that's left of your dreams. I'm the only one who can help you. **(Pg 61-62)** Did you ever read your chart in the nut house?

GWEN: No, they didn't let us . . . why?

GWEN II: Well, I did. . . A serious personality disorder due to critically low feelings of self-worth who is potentially homicidal. *(she looks dangerous)*

GWEN: *(Frightened)* What's that supposed to mean?

GWEN II: It means that son of a bitch who dumped us and got married to Miss Mummy Face with her CPA and her Volvo is finally, finally going to care about us when I point a gun in his stinking face!

GWEN: *(Terrified)* No . . . I couldn't kill anybody . . . not anybody! *(changing the subject)* I want you to tell me why I don't want to see my kids.

GWEN II: **(Pg 63-64)** You don't want to see your kids, Gwen, because you hate your kids. You convinced yourself that he dumped you because of the kids. He was never a family man. You knew that. You got yourself knocked up twice, thinking that would make him stay with you, but it didn't!

GWEN: *(with increasing rage)* . . . get out . . . get out of my house! Get out of my house!

GWEN II: Remember what you did that night you called him and she answered?

GWEN: I cried myself to sleep.

GWEN II: *(Scoffs)* You slapped the girl across the face, told her it was all her fault that he left you, and you didn't feed either one of 'em for three days. The girl went to school bruised and wearing dirty clothes. The boy sat in a corner and cried while you laid in bed in a drunken stupor, moaning over the fact that stupid asshole left you. The school called the county child abuse authorities and next stop, Estelle's nut house!

GWEN: **(Pg 65)** I do not hate my children!

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GWEN II: **(Pg 68)** *(dismissively)* Get hold of yourself, Gweny. We need to think of something to do for entertainment this evening. Um . . . I know! Let's tell each other secrets.

GWEN: I don't have any secrets.

GWEN II: True. But I've got a few. They're just oozing out of me. *(She goes to the bed and reaches in between the mattress and pulls out a handgun.)* Secret number one. *(waves the gun in Gwen's face)* Remember this?

GWEN: *(backs away in fear)* No!

GWEN II: Sure you do. Last month? Meeting at the nut house. Sneak upstairs afterwards hopin' that crazy Billie forgot to take her gun from beneath the floorboards. Well she forgot! **(Pg 74-76)** *(forcing the gun into Gwen's hands.)*

GWEN: *(Starts to cry)* . . . I'm . . . I'm afraid . . . of you.

GWEN II: *(Grabs Gwen's hands and tries to get her to aim the gun at her head)* Do it! Get it over with!

GWEN: *(Struggling)* No!

GWEN II: You're a loser, Gwen, A Loser. He's gone. He's married . . .and he ain't ever gonna call you again. Do it, Gwen. Put a dignified end to this . . this joke . . . this farce we've become.

GWEN: *(in a very weak voice that begins to gain strength as she speaks)* . . . things can change . . . people can make things change . . . we . . . we can reunite.

GWEN II: It takes a powerful chop to cut a person in two like this, but when it happens, there's no point in going on.

GWEN: . . . people still fall in love . . . people still fall in love . . .

GWEN II: But not people like you . . . not people like us. *(Gwen slowly raises the gun and points it at Gwen II. She shoots her)* Now you've only got one bullet left. . . don't miss. Embed it in what's left of your brain. I'll survive for a short time after you're gone. I shall speak the last word. **(Pg 77)** A name . . . what's the last name you want me to say, Gwen?

GWEN: *(In control now . . . a long beat)* Alright. Say your children's names!

GWEN II: *(turns away defiantly)* I don't have any children.

GWEN: **(Pg 78)** You are a woman with two children, a son and a daughter. *(She tosses the gun on the bed and commands)* Say their names!

GWEN II: Say them yourself.

GWEN: **(Pg 79-80)** Say YOUR name . . . SAY IT!

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GWEN II: *(battling to stay in control she forces out the words)* I am Gwen Kessler. I just got out of the nut house. My life has been an abysmal failure and I possess no foreseeable future. I am angry. I abused and neglected my children. I have a gun with one bullet in it . . .

GWEN: *(Shoves her away)* I am Gwen Kessler . . . and I have two children . . . Diane and David **(Pg 82)** I'm going to call my children!

GWEN II: **(Pg 83)** *(Desperately trying to maintain control)* You abandoned them! They hate you! You said it was their fault he left you! You wished you never had them!

GWEN: *(with conviction)* My children love me . . .and I'm going to call them.

GWEN II: *(weakly)* But what will we say? We hurt them! What will we say?

GWEN: *(with strength as GWEN II fades)* . . . we'll say their names *(Picks up the phone and begins to dial)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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